



Consistent rivalry: This was the second consecutive final between India and Sri Lanka, after the Asia Cup in Dubai earlier this month.

Cup, has made its intention of expanding cricket to counter football, covertly and overtly, known. Development initiatives with Associates, infrastructure assistance and advocacy have spruced up since the turn of the decade.

The Indonesian ecosystem is a direct beneficiary, having landed Asian Cricket Council membership a few years ago. Cricket chief Abhiram Singh Yadav credits the role of former ACC president and incumbent ICC chair Jay Shah for making room for Indonesia at the high tables of Asian cricket.

"Mr. Shah thinks quite broadly about the game. He sees the potential of global markets. Indonesia is a country with a population of over 200 million. We are a G20 member. That recognition also came through in Mr. Sanjog Gupta's (ICC CEO) visit. Both are working towards developing emerging markets and looking at non-traditional cricketing nations. With the sport now in the Olympics, this is the only way we can make cricket inclusive," Yadav told *Sportstar*.

"Cricket wants to work towards

becoming bigger than FIFA, and that requires looking deep into different international markets. As an Associate member, we want to support that vision. Indonesia, Thailand, Malaysia, Japan and Korea are promising markets, and we want to be a model for others to follow," Yadav added. UAE, too, has a promising women's side drawing heavily from the expat Indian population in the Gulf. While the national side benefits from their quality, the Emirates Cricket Board has been trying to foster an interest in the sport among natives too.

"I won't say that it's a challenge," Emirates Cricket Board COO Subhan Ahmed told *Sportstar*. "If you look at the overall demographics of this country, about 80 per cent of the population is expat. So it's natural that the sports that they have played back home and that culture travels. The infrastructure here has grown because of it. We have 62 grounds across the seven states in the Emirates. There are some Full Members who do not have that kind of base. The local Emirati population is always a part of our plans. We don't envisage a complete takeover by the local population, but we do anticipate greater participation given how much it can do for overall community unity here," he added.

Indonesia, too, faced the same predicament of leaning entirely on

the diaspora, but Yadav underlined that the setup is on a war footing to ensure cricket can become a 100 per cent localised sport.

Sports tourism has emerged as a way to galvanise smaller boards, as Yadav pointed out earlier, allowing them to tap newer markets within cricket. Sanjog Gupta has also identified China as a potential cash cow, hoping to convert at least some of its 1.4 billion people into cricket fanatics.

The ICC pumped USD 1.5 million into cricket in the nation, broadcast World Cup games in Mandarin to whet the appetite for the game, and has also seen the cricketing system build three top-level cricket venues, including a new 1,500-seat stadium in Taicang that is primed to host domestic and international matches and provide a training base for the national teams. The Marylebone Cricket Club has chimed in with support, saying it will send a women's team there for an overseas tour next year.

The women's national team, made almost entirely of homegrown players, has climbed 10 spots in the rankings over the last two years, which only underlines why that faith isn't misplaced. That Asiad washout stings that much more now, right?

Dissonance at the top

The one-sided nature of this fairytale Asian romp was known to all before the curtains rose. But even for the world's most successful team, backed by the world's richest board and cricketing circulatory system, multi-sport events bring with them nostalgia and old-time achievement.

Indian skipper Harmanpreet Kaur, for instance, grew up in Punjab, where tales of legendary Olympians were often served alongside a child's daily meals. The Games — of the Asian, Commonwealth and Olympic kind — hold a special place. It's why her creaking knees want to carry on till she makes it to Los Angeles 2028, till that Olympic gold finds its way to her neck.

While parallels can be drawn between India's comfort and dominance here and what might lie